The BJP's response to this critique has always been to refer back to its 2014 election slogan of 'Sab Ka Saath Sab Ka Vikas'. It insists that there has never been any religious bias in the implementation of its governmental welfare schemes and accuses the secular liberal chattering classes and the Opposition of misrepresenting its politics. Narendra Modi pointedly referred to this in his May 2019 acceptance speech. Calling the verdict a riposte to the secular critique, Modi argued in his moment of triumph that this was one of the primary lessons of the election. 'This dramebazi has been on for years, but for thirty continuous years especially,' he said in a speech at the BJP's headquarters in Delhi. 'It was such a printout, such a tag that had become so fashionable. That whatever you do, you put it on. It was like doing a Ganga bath to get good credit [punya]. The name of this tag—and it was totally fake—was secularism. There were slogans chanted, "Seculars unite, Seculars unite". You would have seen that from 2014 to 2019, that entire jamaat [community] stopped talking only. In this election, not even one political party dared to wear the mask of secularism to misdirect Hindustan. They got exposed.'[6]

The truth is that, while it has not won successive elections because of Hindutva and its core supporters alone—that would simply not be possible—there is no question that, after 2014, the BJP sharpened its focus on an assertive Hinduness as an idiom of the party. This goes beyond iconic issues or historic symbols—there is now an emphasis on Hinduness and nationalism being synonymous. The ascent of Yogi Adityanath, the saffron robe-wearing mathadheesh of the Gorakhnath peeth, as chief minister in UP is symbolic of this hard turn to first principles. Yogi, like Modi, has often argued publicly that secularism, as it has been practised in India, is a 'false' narrative—drawing from L.K. Advani's original critique of pseudo-secularism in the 1980s—that Hinduism as a religion is essentially secular, and therefore India as a country is secular essentially because it is Hindu.[7] As he put it, soon after taking charge as chief minister in 2017, 'The government should be panth-nirpeksh [community-neutral], not dharm-nirpeksh [religion-neutral]. We should understand the difference between panth and dharm. Secularism as a word means panth-nirpeksh not dharm-